

3. NULL SUBJECTS IN OLD GERMANIC

3.1. Introduction

The Old Germanic (OG) languages that are discussed in this chapter are Old High German (OHG), Old English (OE), Old Icelandic (OI) and Old Swedish (OS).¹ In spite of the similar designations, these languages were in usage during different periods of time. OE and OHG are approximately 500 years older than OI and OS. At about the time when OE and OHG are developing into later language varieties (Middle English and Middle High German, respectively), OI and OS first appear in texts written with the Latin script. A rough outline of the chronological relations can be found in table 3:1.

Table 3:1. Old Germanic timeline.

language/period	600	700	800	900	1000	1100	1200	1300	1400	1500
Old English										
Old High German										
Old Icelandic										
Old Swedish										

As for OE and OHG, there are a handful of earlier runic inscriptions, but longer coherent texts, which constitute a prerequisite for syntactic studies, first appear around 650 and 750.

The exact division of each OG language in different periods is of course a matter of continuous dispute. The traditional dating is often based on extant texts, the preservation of which into modern times is quite coincidental. For instance, the oldest preserved OS manuscript is *Äldre Västgötalagen* ('The Old Westro-Gothic Law'), which was written around 1225. For this reason, the Old Swedish period is assumed to commence then, although the fact that the language of that time happened to be documented in the Latin alphabet certainly does not imply that there was any radical shift in the spoken language which could justify a linguistic division between Runic Swedish and Old Swedish at

¹ In his introduction to the OG languages, Robinson (1992) includes Gothic, Old Norse, Old Saxon, Old English, Old Frisian, Old Low Franconian and Old High German. Old Norse corresponds to North Germanic, which later developed into East (Insular) and West (Mainland) Scandinavian, but Old Norse and Old Icelandic are often used interchangeably. Old Saxon is another term for Old Low German or Old Dutch.

that exact year. Similar considerations naturally apply also for the dating of OE, OHG and OI.

Null thematic subjects can be attested in all of these OG languages, and, interestingly, the null subjects also disappear within the timespan illustrated in table 3:1. The exception is Icelandic, where null subjects continued to be a grammatical option until the 19th century.

The Old Germanic languages are syntactically similar, and it has even been claimed that Old English, Old Icelandic, Old High German etc. should be considered mere dialects of one and the same language:

I am proposing in this book that it is appropriate to think of a single Old Germanic language with dialects of Old English, Old Icelandic, Old High German and others. (Davis 2006:15).

The survey of the properties of null subjects in OG that is presented in the subsections below gives partial support to the assumption presented by Davis (2006); the resemblance between these languages is in this particular respect quite remarkable. It is however important to point out that although null thematic subjects do appear in OE, OHG, OI and OS, it is by no means certain that all of the OG languages share this property. In a study of Old Frisian syntax, de Haan (2010:53) states that there were few null subjects in Old Frisian, showing with examples that even expletive subjects were overt, as a rule.

Traditionally it is claimed that in the older stages of the Germanic languages, the subject need not be lexically realized. Although subjectless sentences do occur in Old Frisian, it is normally the case that subjects are overtly expressed. (de Haan 2010:53)

Yet again, the possibility of thematic null subjects in OE was for a long time denied (the issue is still somewhat controversial), and hence the existence, frequency and syntactic distribution of thematic null subjects in any given OG language variety should be seen as an unexplored research possibility as long as no contemporary, comprehensive, and syntactically informed study has been conducted.

A substantial part of all OG texts are translations from Latin (or, rather, Germanic versions of Latin texts). Since Latin is a classic null subject language, the hypothesis that the OG null subjects are instances of loan syntax may seem

plausible (cf. Eggenberger 1961:167, who claims that the closer to Latin an OHG text is, the higher the ratio of null subjects). This hypothesis is discussed and convincingly rejected by van Gelderen (2000:132ff) as well as by Axel (2007:319ff; see also Schlachter 2012:157–158). One of the issues Axel underlines is that there are distinct, language-specific morphosyntactic restrictions for null subjects in OHG.

One serious problem of the loan-syntax approach is that even though it may be possible to envisage a situation where a feature of a foreign-language source is consistently ‚copied’ into the target language, it is hard to explain why this copying process should be banned from specific morphosyntactic environments defined by the target language. (Axel 2007:319)

The idea that the Latin source has influenced the syntax of the target languages has been discussed also for OI and OS (cf. Wollin 2009, 2011, for instance), but since the earliest texts in these cases mostly consist of sagas and provincial laws, which are supposed to be more or less autochthonic, the problem has not been as salient as for OE and OHG.

Another possible Germanic null subject language for which the loan syntax hypothesis has been intensively discussed is Gothic (see Schlachter 2012:161ff). The Gothic Bible, the only comprehensive Gothic text, was written by the Visigothic bishop Wulfila during the 4th century AD, and it is preserved in manuscripts from the 5th and 6th centuries AD (the most prominent being *Codex Argentus*, one of the treasures of the university library in Uppsala). In Wulfila’s Bible, subject pronouns are in general omitted, a syntactic feature which either may be caused by influence from the Greek source text (which has not been preserved) or which may be an inherent property of Gothic. For instance, Abraham (1993:121) and Ferraresi (2005:47) claim that Gothic without doubt is a null subject language, due to the richness of its verbal agreement system, while Hopper (1975:31f) argues that the null subjects in Gothic were caused by influence from Greek and Latin:

In the early Germanic languages the use of a pronominal subject was probably usual; the omission of the pronoun is sporadic in original texts, especially poetic ones, and it is only in works which adhere closely to a Greek or Latin model that the subject is frequently left unexpressed. In Gothic, as Meillet has shown there are many examples of pronouns added against the Vorlage, but almost no places where the translator has

failed to render a Greek pronoun. (Hopper 1975:31-32; quoted from Schlachter 2012:161)

A compromise between these two opinions is represented by Fertig (2000), who claims that in Gothic, null subject pronouns were predominantly used with topic antecedents, while pronouns with non-topic antecedents were overt. Similar findings have been reported by Frascarelli (2007) for modern Italian (see chapter 2).

The ancient language of Gothic constitutes a challenge for contemporary syntacticians, primarily due to the paucity of texts. The selection of OG languages to include in this chapter depends upon the availability of sufficiently rich source material, which has allowed for and facilitated detailed studies of each particular language, with a focus on null subjects, as mentioned in the introduction (chapter 1). For this reason, Old Frisian, Old Saxon and Old Danish are for instance not included.

In the remainder of this chapter, I present and discuss relevant data concerning thematic null subjects in OE, OHG, OI and OS in separate sections (sections 3.1–3.4). Previous studies by van Gelderen (2000, xxxx), Axel (2007), Schlachter (2012), Sigurdsson (1993) and Håkansson (2008) constitute the foundation for what is presented in the respective sections.

The chapter is concluded with a section where the linguistic properties of the null subjects in the OG languages are compared (section 3.5) and a summarizing discussion (section 3.6).

3.2. Null subjects in Old English

The presence of thematic null subjects in Old English (OE) is somewhat controversial. On the one hand, Hulk & van Kemenade (1995:245) explicitly state that there are no such null subjects in OE: “The phenomenon of referential pro-drop does not exist in OE.” On the other hand, Mitchell (1985) discusses subject pronouns in OE and comes to the conclusion that “[...] a subject pronoun need not be expressed” (Mitchell 1985 I:109) and that “This non-expression of a pronoun subject which can be supplied from a preceding clause must be accepted as idiomatic OE” (Mitchell 1985 I:633). Furthermore, there are a number of traditional linguistic studies discussing OE subject pronouns,

overt and covert, in various texts, such as Pogatscher (1901), Berndt (1956) and Visser (1963–1973). Drawing on these earlier works (among others), van Gelderen (2000:149, 2011) concludes that thematic null subjects were relatively common in OE, especially in the earlier stages of the language. In late OE, null subjects are getting increasingly infrequent, and no, or very few, null subjects are attested in Middle English.

An example of a null subject in OE is presented in (3:1). It is taken from *Beowulf* (van Gelderen 2000:127).

- (3:1) Sona þæt gesawon
soon that saw
‘Soon they saw that’

In the example in (3:1), the unexpressed subject cannot be assumed to be an instance of topic drop, since the clause initial position is unavailable. Likewise, thematic null subjects also appeared in OE embedded clauses, as shown by the examples in (3:2), which are taken from van Gelderen (2011), quoting Pogatscher (1901:176). Also these examples come from *Beowulf*.

- (3:2) a. þæt ic gume cystum godne funde beaga bryttan breac þonne moste
that I manly-virtue good found ring dispenser enjoyed as-long could
‘that I found a noble bestower of rings and enjoyed it as long as **I** could.’
- b. swylcum gifeþe bið þæt þone hilderæs hal gedigeð
such given be that the battle-storm unhurt endure
‘May it be that **he** will withstand unhurt the heat of the battle.’

Topic drop is of course not possible from embedded clauses, in general, and since both of the embedded clauses in (3:2) furthermore are verb-final, they do not constitute any main clause (i.e., V2 or root) contexts, from which topic drop arguably could be assumed to be possible. These examples also demonstrate clearly that verb raising (to T or C) is not necessary for the licensing of null subjects in OE.

In OE, both singular and plural subject pronouns appear as thematic null subjects, irrespective of the fact that person agreement only was present in the singular verb forms: “In common with Old Saxon and Old Frisian, Old English did not distinguish person in the plural of any verb”. (Mitchell 1985 I:9). The

fact that there does not seem to be any difference between omission of subjects relating to number in OE is unexpected, if the presence of thematic null subjects is assumed to be connected with sufficiently rich verb agreement.

Rather than number, the distinguishing factor for OE null subjects is person, as pointed out by van Gelderen (2000): “In summary, Old English has pro-drop, especially with third person [...]” (van Gelderen 2000:137). Hence, 3p subjects are more frequently omitted than 1p and 2p subjects, and there are only marginal differences between the rate of omission of 3p singular and 3p plural subjects (see below), although there is a unique (albeit non-distinct, since the subjects pronouns also were marked for gender) verb form for 3p singular, but not for 3p plural (see table 3:2). The plural form is in the present tense invariably *-aþ*, while the plural past form varies between *-dun*, *-don* and *-dan* due to lexical features.

Table 3:2. OE verb agreement (weak verbs, present and past tense indicative).

num.	pers.	present	past
sing.	1	-e	-de
	2	-es(t)	-des(t)
	3	-eþ	-de
plural	1	-aþ	-dun,
	2		-don,
	3		-dan
infinitive		-an	

Table 3:2 shows that there were distinct verb forms for 1sg and 2sg subjects in OE, and that the form for 3sg was unique. One would accordingly expect that singular subject pronouns were omitted more frequently than plural subject pronouns, under the assumption that null subjects are dependent on “rich” inflection, but this is not the case. Berndt (1956:65ff) presents illustrative data from two OE texts (the Lindisfarne and Rushworth gospels, both from around 700 AD), which are quoted by van Gelderen (2000:133, 2011) as well as by Rosenkvist (2009:159). The percentage of overt and null subjects in these two texts, broken down into number and person, is presented in table 3:3.

Table 3:3. Null subjects in two OE texts (after Berndt 1956:65ff)

num.	pers.	total	overt subj.	null subj.
sing.	1	1632	97% (1587)	3% (45)
	2	799	91% (727)	9% (72)
	3	3728	26,5% (773)	73,5% (2955)
plural	1	321	99% (317)	1% (4)
	2	1217	91% (1104)	9% (113)
	3	2066	26% (527)	74% (1539)
Σ		9763	52% (5035)	48% (4728)

The data in table 3:3 very amply demonstrate that OE null subjects were not dependent on richness of verb agreement – the distinct verb forms in singular did not license null subjects in any higher degree than the non-distinct plural verb form. For instance, the clearly distinct form for 2sg (*-est*) still requires that 2sg subject pronouns be overt (only 1 % are null), whereas the syncretic plural form allows for 9,5 % of the 2pl subjects to be null. Still, the most striking data in table 3 is of course that 3sg and 3pl subjects are null in a majority of the cases, while 1p and 2p subjects almost always are overt.

In spite of the apparent lack of a relation between agreement and null subjects in OE, van Gelderen (2011) argues that the person split in OE is caused by differences in interpretability of agreement.

Starting with first and second person agreement, a reanalysis occurs in late Old English from interpretable to uninterpretable. One can think of this as strength as well. In Old English, pro-drop is possible but there is a person split suggesting that, if we think of pro-drop as ‘strength’ of the tense and agreement features, third person features are the ones that retain the interpretable features the longest. Once the interpretable features are lost on the verb, a pronoun with interpretable features becomes obligatory. (van Gelderen 2011)

Given that the OE agreement is considerably richer in singular (two distinct forms) than it is in plural (see table 3:2), and that there is virtually no difference in frequency between null 3sg and null 3p subjects (see table 3:3), the explanation provided by van Gelderen (2011) infers that there is no correlation at all between visible morphological agreement and syntactic interpretability. Given basic assumptions about the prerequisites for null thematic subjects as

presented by e.g. Rizzi (1986) and much subsequent work, this is unexpected. In other words – it is inconceivable why non-distinct 3pl agreement would be interpretable while distinct 2sg agreement would be uninterpretable in OE.

Furthermore, if a null subject is to be identified via verb agreement, a commonly acknowledged condition is that the verb and the subject pronoun are adjacent in the overt syntactic structure (see the discussion in chapter 2), allowing for a pre-interface Agree-relation. The fact that OE null subjects appear in verb-final embedded clauses (see examples in 3:2) is a solid argument against the necessity of such a syntactic relation (but see the following section). A final point is that Mitchell (1985 I:633) claims that OE null subjects were “supplied from a preceding clause”, i.e., that they were identified by antecedents in the discourse rather than by clause-internal agreement. As will be shown in the remainder of this chapter, similar observations regarding the distribution and identification of thematic null subjects have been made also for OHG, OI and OS.

Summing up, we have found that there are thematic null subjects in OE. These null subjects appear in main clauses as well as in embedded clauses, and the position of the finite verb and the verb agreement do not have any bearing on the frequency or distribution of these null subjects. 3p null subjects are furthermore considerably more common than 1p and 2p null subjects, both in the singular and in the plural.

3.3. Null subjects in Old High German

The classic study of subject pronouns in OHG is Eggenberger (1961). As mentioned above, Eggenberger claimed that the null subjects in OHG were due to influence from Greek and Latin source texts. Subsequent studies by Axel (2007), Axel & Weiß (2010, 2011) and Schlachter (2012) suggest, however, that null thematic pronouns were a part of proper OHG syntax, with language-specific morphosyntactic and syntactic properties.

In her comprehensive study of Old High German (OHG) syntax, Axel (2007) devotes an entire chapter to a discussion about the syntactic properties of OHG null subjects (referential as well as non-referential), with a focus on verb placement (Axel 2007:chapter 6). As in OE, null subjects were most common in

the earliest stages of the language, i.e. in the 8th and 9th centuries: “Referential null subjects only occur in the 8th and 9th century texts” (Axel & Weiß 2011:22). Two examples are presented in (3:3) (both are quoted from from Axel 2007:307, 310):

- (3:3) a. Druthin ist auh
Lord is also
 ‘**He** is also the Lord’
- b. uuanta sehente nigisehent
because seeing not-see-3pl
 ‘Because seeing **they** do not see’<sup>[L]
[SEP]</sup>

OHG is also similar to OE when it concerns the person reference of null thematic subjects; third person null subjects are by far the most frequent:

Referential null subjects are attested in all persons and numbers. However [...], it is only in third person singular and plural that the null variant is used more frequently than the overt one. (Axel 2007:314)

Table 3:4 shows the relevant percentages. The data are taken from Schlachter (2012:184), who has studied two OHG texts, and have been collapsed into one table.

Table 3:4. Null subjects in two OHG texts (after Schlachter 2012:184)

num.	pers.	total	overt subj.	null subj.
sing.	1	60	90% (54)	10% (6)
	2	19	74% (14)	26% (5)
	3	161	68% (110)	32% (51)
plural	1	14	91% (13)	9% (1)
	2	32	78% (25)	21% (7)
	3	61	57% (35)	43% (26)
Σ		347	72% (251)	28% (96)

In Axel’s study (2007) of three OHG texts, 57%, i.e., a majority, of all 3p subjects were omitted, whereas only 21% 1p and 25% 2p subject pronouns were null. These two studies accordingly both show, independently, that 1p null

subjects were least frequent in OHG, followed by 2p and 3p null subjects. The marked person asymmetry was observed also by Eggenberger (1961:170), who considered 3p subject pronouns to be a grammatical domain particularly prone to be influenced by Latin.

Unlike OE, the verb agreement in OHG distinguished six different verb forms in present tense indicative – each verb form was marked for person and number (see table 3:5).

Table 3:5. OHG verb agreement (weak verbs, present and past tense indicative; taken from Braune & Reiffenstein 2004).

num.	pers.	present	past
sing.	1	-u, -om, -em	-ta
	2	-is, -es(t), - os(t)	-tos, -ost
	3	-it, -et, -ot	-ta
plural	1	-mes, -en, -on	-tum, - un
	2	-et, -ot	-tut
	3	-ent, -ont	-tun
infinitive		-an	

In the present tense, there are few syncretisms in the OHG verb declension paradigm, as shown in table 3:5 (only 3sg and 2pl coincide in some cases). It thus seems possible to assume a connection between “rich” agreement and thematic null subjects in OHG. However, the person asymmetry discussed above does not fall out from the data in table 3:5; the agreement morphology does not vindicate that 3p subject pronouns are omitted more frequently than other subject pronouns. Furthermore, both Axel (2007) and Schlachter (2012) note that the diachronic development of OHG appears to contradict such an assumption – the null subjects were lost before the late OHG period although there were no concomitant changes in the declension system:

In the late Old High German period subjects pronouns are almost always realised overtly [...] (Axel & Weiß 2011:29f).

Summing up, referential null subjects were largely lost in the OHG period even though there was no substantial weakening of inflectional endings. (Axel 2007:323)

Zusammenfassend lässt sich sagen, dass die Flexionsmorphologie nicht ursächlich für den Rückgang der Nullsubjektskonstruktion verantwortlich gemacht werden kann. (Schlachter 2012:184)²

In spite of the richness of verb agreement, the OHG null subjects accordingly were dependent on some other grammatical device in order to be felicitously identified.

Another syntactic feature that Axel (2007) observes is that the null subjects in OHG seem to be restricted to main clauses: “[...] OHG null subjects occurred in main clauses and not in subordinate clauses.” (Axel 2007:299). Although Axel acknowledges that some null subjects can be found in embedded clauses in OHG, she proposes that these clauses always display main clause word order (i.e., the finite verb has moved to C), thereby not contradicting her proposed generalisation. All embedded OHG clauses with the finite verb in final position thus require an overt subject; only when the finite verb appears in second position a null subject is possible, according to Axel (2007). A few counter-examples are explained as translation errors or just as simple mistakes by the scribe. The same view is maintained by Axel & Weiß (2011:24): “The main/subordinate asymmetry shows that Old High German null subjects depend on verb fronting”.

Axel’s generalization is challenged by data presented by Schlachter (2012:174ff). She underlines that thematic null subjects actually do appear regularly in OHG verb-final embedded clauses, and that such null subjects therefore should be seen as part of regular OHG syntax. Eggenberger (1961) and Schlachter find that about 15% of the subject pronouns in embedded clauses are omitted, while Axel & Weiß (2011:24) give the figure 9–15%. This is a far greater number than expected, given the hypothesis presented by Axel (2007) and by Axel & Weiß (2011), Schlachter argues. Two of Schlachter’s (2012:175) examples are presented in (3:4).

² “As a summary, one may say that the agreement morphology cannot be responsible for the decline of the possibility of the null subjects.” (HR translation)

- (3:4) a. so sama so hear after quhidhit
which hereafter says
 'which **he** says hereafter'
- b. daz inan lei do tin^[SEP]
that him accused
 'that **he** him accused'

Schlachter (2012:175) observes that “Keiner dieser Belege stellt einen V2-Nebensatz dar oder kann als Übersetzungsfehler betrachtet werden”.³ Having concluded that neither verb morphology nor any Agree-relation between the finite verb are instrumental when it comes to thematic null subjects in OHG, Schlachter ventures to explore other possible explanations for how OHG null subjects were identified. She suggests that OHG had a complex CP-field with two topic positions, as illustrated in (3:5).

(3:5) [(Top) – Fok – (Top) – Infl – V]

Having shown that OHG V3-clauses with lexical subjects can be attested, Schlachter claims that both overt and null subjects could appear in the lower SpecTopP, thereby analysing the thematic null subjects as pre-verbal also in V2-clauses. This differs from Axel (2007) and Axel & Weiß (2010, 2011), who claim that null subjects in V2-clauses are post-verbal. Schlachter’s view of the OHG null subjects is thus that they were independent of the agreement features expressed by the finite verb – which is in accord with the observation that the OHG null subjects disappeared without any changes in the declension paradigm – and that they instead should be seen as a form of non-initial topic drop, enabled by the lower TopP, that could relate to an antecedent in the previous discourse. When OHG successively develops into a regular V2-language during the OHG period, the lower TopP disappears and non-initial subject pronouns must hence always be spelled out in late OHG (Schlachter 2012:207). This is in line with both Faarlund’s (2003) analysis of null subjects in Old Norse, and Håkansson (2008), who has studied null subjects in OS (see below).

An example such as (3:3a) is accordingly analysed differently by Axel (2007) and Schlachter (2012), as illustrated in (3:6).

³ “None of these examples represent an embedded V2-clause or can be regarded as translation errors.” (HR translation)

(3:6) Druthin ist auh (= 3:3 a)

Lord is also

‘**He** is also the Lord’

Axel’s (2007) analysis: [CP Druthin C ist_i [SpecTP *pro* T t_i auh]]

Schalchter’s (2012) analysis: [TopP [FokP Druthin [TopP *pro* [T ist auh]]]]

The empirical data that favour Schlachter's analysis are the independence between verb agreement and null subjects, the independence between the position of the finite verb and null subjects, and the fact that V3-structures with overt subjects actually did occur in OHG.

To conclude, we have found that there are thematic null subjects in OHG, predominantly in the early OHG period. As in OE, these null subjects appear in main clauses as well as in embedded clauses. While the OHG agreement morphology is distinct in almost the entire paradigm, the attested person asymmetry and the eventual loss of thematic null subjects in late OHG, without any weakening of the agreement system, suggest that the null subjects were independent of agreement on the finite verb. Likewise, the position of the finite verb does not appear to play any crucial role, since null thematic subjects relatively frequently occur in embedded, verb-final clauses, which do not allow for any pre-interface Agree-relation.

3.3. Null subjects in Old Icelandic

Also in Old Icelandic (OI), null thematic subjects can be found. Sigurðsson (1993), drawing on earlier work by Hjartardóttir (1987), is careful to distinguish between topic drop and “genuine *pro*-drop”, and presents a number of examples of the latter (see 3:7).

(3:7). a. þá skar Rögnvaldr jarl [hár hans], en aðr hafði verit úskorit

then cut R. jarl hair his but before had been uncut

‘Then R. cut his hair, but **it** had been uncut before.’

b. ok kom hann þangat ok var Hoskuldr uti, er reið í tún.

and came he there and was H. outdoors when rode into field

‘And he came there, and H. was outdoors when **he** rode into the field.’

Just as in OE and OHG, third person null subject pronouns were more frequent than other types, as pointed out by Sigurðsson: “dropping of first and second person arguments was very rare” (1993:253). Another apparent similarity is that the Icelandic null subjects disappeared (during the 18th and 19th centuries (Hróarsdóttir 1996)) without any concomitant changes in the verbal agreement paradigm, as also underlined by Sigurðsson (1993:248f) and reiterated by Sigurðsson (2011).

[...] Icelandic generally lost subject drop in subordinate clauses and in main clauses with a lexicalized Spec,C without any concomitant change of grammar—in particular, without any relevant weakening of its robust agreement morphology (Sigurðsson 2011:276)

The OI verb agreement, which has remained more or less unchanged into contemporary Icelandic, is illustrated in table 3:6.

Table 3:6. OI verb agreement (weak verbs, present and past tense indicative).

num.	pers.	present	past
sing.	1	-i	-aða
	2	-ir, -ar	-aðir
	3		-aði
plural	1	-um	-oðum
	2	-ið	-oðuð
	3	-an	-oðu
infinitive		-an	

As shown by table 3:6, neither the agreement form for 3sg, nor for 3pl, are distinct in the present tense – there is a common form for 2sg and 3sg, and 3pl coincides with the infinite, which makes the form non-distinct (cf. the discussion in Vikner 1995, 1997). On the other hand, the forms for 1sg, 1pl and 2pl are clearly distinct and would hence allow for null subjects, had “rich” verb agreement been the deciding factor. Still, 3p thematic null subjects were most frequent in OI. This indicates very clearly that verb agreement did not constitute an essential licensing factor for null subjects in OI.

Unlike null subjects in OE and OHG, it appears that omitted subjects were quite common also in OI embedded clauses (cf. 3:7b). Sigurðsson claims that “null subjects were frequent in subordinate clauses, especially in adverbial clauses” (1993:262). However, there are no quantitative studies of null subjects in OI that may be compared with the OHG data provided by Axel (2007) and Schlachter (2012), or with the OS data provided by Håkansson (2008; see below). Although Hróarsdóttir (1996:130) has studied the distribution of null subjects in main and embedded clauses, the numbers that she presents are absolute; she reports that she has found 13 instances of OI null thematic subjects in her text sample from 1730–1750, but neither the number of overt subjects in the sample nor the clausal context is provided. Therefore, we cannot make any conclusions regarding the frequency of null subjects or their syntactic distribution. Were OI null subjects perhaps restricted to main clauses, as Axel (2007) argues was the case in OHG? Below, I present a corpus study that provides tentative answers to some of these questions.

The recently developed Icelandic Parsed Historical Corpus (IcePaHC; see Wallenberg et al 2011) comprises about 1 000 000 words from 63 Icelandic texts. The oldest text (The First Grammarian, a brilliant essay about OI phonetics and orthography) is written about 1150, and the youngest is from 2008. The corpus is tagged and syntactically annotated, and it is freely available on the Internet.⁴

In table 3:7, the number of thematic null subjects (NS) in a sample of Icelandic texts from the 12th, 13th, 14th, 15th and 19th centuries, plus one text (Ofsi) from 2008, is presented. The texts are ordered diachronically, i.e., the 14th century text Grettir was produced earlier in that century (1300–1320) than the text BandamennM (1330–1370).⁵ The abbreviations in the table are explained in the accompanying key.

⁴ The URL is:

[http://www.linguist.is/icelandic_treebank/Icelandic_Parsed_Historical_Corpus_\(IcePaHC\)](http://www.linguist.is/icelandic_treebank/Icelandic_Parsed_Historical_Corpus_(IcePaHC))

⁵ All information about the texts is taken from the IcePaHC website (February 2013).

Table 3:7. Thematic null subjects in IcePaHC.

cent.	text	genre	words	OS	NS	%NS	emb. NS	%emb. NS
12 th	First Grammarian	science	4 439	176	36	20	30	83
	Homiliubok	sermon	40 871	2009	45	2	25	55
13 th	Jartein	saga	10 328	815	40	5	33	87
	Sturlunga	saga	22 720	2220	35	2	11	31
	Jomsvikingar	saga	21 133	1503	47	3	14	30
	Morkinskinna	history	25 017	2136	101	5	27	27
14 th	Grettir	saga	20 563	2045	38	2	24	63
	BandamennM	saga	13 542	1198	59	5	26	44
	Finnbogi	saga	23 040	2322	54	2	13	24
15 th	Gunnar	saga	8 770	932	20	2	10	50
	Viglundur	saga	13 453	1276	22	2	9	40
	Vilhjalmur	saga	23 041	2385	59	2	29	49
19 th	Hellismenn	saga	14 988	1371	41	3	20	49
	Piltur	fiction	17 837	1425	23	2	12	52
	Hugvekjur	sermon	20 370	1041	4	< 1	1	25
	Torfhildur	fiction	27 192	1937	23	1	15	65
	Voggur	fiction	1 951	127	0	–	0	–
	Grimur	fiction	7 341	593	1	< 1	1	100
	Vordraumur	fiction	10 753	739	4	< 1	1	25
21 th	Ofsi	saga	21 144	1 165	22	2	10	45
	Σ		327 349	27 415	675	2	301	45

Key to table 3:7

OS	=	overt NP-subject
NS	=	null thematic subject
%NS	=	percentage null thematic subjects (NS/OS)
emb. NS	=	null thematic subjects in embedded clauses
%emb. NS	=	percentage emb. NS (emb. NS/NS)

The data in table 3:7 show that thematic null subjects were relatively infrequent even in the oldest period of Icelandic. The earliest text, The First Grammarian, stands out since a fifth of all subjects are omitted. This is however due to the large number of impersonal constructions in this scientific text, which infer a high frequency of clauses without NP-subjects, as well as null impersonal subjects, i.e., this is a stylistic trait determined by the genre. See example (3:8).

- (3:8) þær þegar er úr einni og hinna sömu tungu hafa gengist eða greinst ,
there so-soon is from one and the same language have gone or branched
 þarf ólíka stafi í að hafa en eigi hina sömu
need different letters to have and not the same
 ‘As soon as one and the same language has been divided, **one** needs different letters
 and not the same.’

In several places in this early text, the exact interpretation of the omitted subject is far from clear, as underlined by the IcePaHC-manual:

Note that in early (Old Icelandic) texts, it may be difficult to distinguish between *exp* and *pro* in cases where there is an empty subject and it has a roughly impersonal (i.e. "maður") interpretation. (IcePaHC manual, February 2013)

This is of course a caveat that may have influenced the number of null subjects that are coded as *pro*, particularly in this early text, which has a marked impersonal character.⁶

The same type of explanation can be applied when it concerns the number of null subjects in Ofsi, which is quite high for such a late text (it is from 2008).⁷ In the saga genre, the style is often archaic, and a feature of the archaic style is (arguably) to omit thematic subjects. Both Ofsi and the early 19th century text *Hellismenn* belong to this venerable Icelandic literary tradition.

In the fiction from the second half of the 19th century, the relative number of null thematic subjects is very low, an indication that thematic null subjects were ousted from Icelandic grammar during this period, as pointed out by Hróarsdóttir (1996) and Sigurðsson (1993). Further relevant changes in Icelandic grammar during the 19th century are the appearance of expletive *það* as a subject, and the loss of OV-word order in embedded clauses (Hróarsdóttir 1996:118ff). Having established this correlation, Hróarsdóttir suggests that these changes are related to each other, and that the driving force is a change in the Icelandic case system; from having been morphologically active until about 1750, it then changes so that it “no longer has any real function” (Hróarsdóttir 1996:132). However, since there are no observable weakening of the Icelandic

⁶ As for modern Icelandic, Sigurðsson (1989:161ff) considers impersonal subjects of the *maður*-type to be non-referential.

⁷ Sigurðsson (2011:276) states “Spelling out the subject is obligatory in present-day Icelandic” but the null subjects in Ofsi indicate that this is a genre related syntactic possibility that is still vivid.

overt case morphology during this period, this hypothesis is not underpinned by empirical data (as pointed out by e.g. Håkansson 2008:194f).

Faarlund (2003) instead suggests that the loss of null subjects during the change from Old Norse to Middle Norwegian is caused by a syntactic grammaticalization of the canonical subject position (SpecTP, or Spec-AgrP, in Faarlund's terminology). He argues that in Old Norse, movement to this position was not driven by syntax, but by pragmatics.

In ON the rule which moves elements to Spec-AgrP does not mention syntactic category. The movement is conditioned by discourse functional or possibly coding properties (such as the lack of weight or complexity). In ON, therefore, this position is apparently an A-bar position, which can serve as a landing site for different phrasal categories. (Faarlund 2003:132)

Old Norse allowed clause final subjects and null subjects (referential as well as expletive), and objects and adverbials furthermore occur in SpecTP. All of these phenomena indicate that SpecTP was not dedicated to subjects only. The subsequent change is taken by Faarlund as a consequence of frequency; even if other items could occupy SpecTP, subject were still most common there, and this resulted in a bias that eventually developed into a requirement.

The frequency of sentences with a subject in this position may at some stage have increased to the point where it was conceived of as basic or obligatory. (Faarlund 2003:132)

Building on Faarlund's analysis of Old Norse in his study of OS null subjects, Håkansson (2008) provides a more elaborate analysis of the factors that made subjects compulsory overt (see section 3.4).

As also shown by table 3:7, null subjects in embedded clauses were considerably more common in OI than in OE and OHG, respectively (this vindicates Sigurðsson's assumption (above) that null subjects in embedded clauses were frequent in OI). In several of the OI texts, a majority of the null subjects appear in embedded contexts.⁸ In example (3:9), which also is taken from The First Grammarian, two conditional clauses lack overt subjects.

⁸ The search query is: IP-SUB* idoms NP-SBJ* AND NP-SBJ* idoms *pro*. I thank Eiríkur Rögnvaldsson (pc) for aiding me in this.

- (3:9) svo sem sól lýsir þar áður var myrkt þá lýsir svo titull bók ef fyrir er ritinn
so like sun shines there earlier was dark then shines so title bok if first is written
 eða orð ef yfir er settur
or word if over is put
 ‘As the sun shines where it previously was dark, there shines the title of the book if it
 is written first or a word if it is put above.’

Unlike OE and OHG (see examples in 3:2 and 3:4, respectively), the embedded clauses in OI were not verb-final, in general. It is therefore possible to assume that the finite verb and the (null) subject often were juxtaposed in OI embedded clauses, allowing for a pre-interface Agree-relation that could facilitate the possible identification of a null subject. Furthermore, Sigurðsson (2011:280) notes that topic drop in contemporary Icelandic obeys the very same restrictions as in contemporary Swedish, even if the Icelandic verb forms for, for instance, 1sg and 1pl are distinct. Hence, in a sentence such as *Liggjum bara á ströndinni* (‘Lie only on the beach’), where the finite verb is inflected for 1pl, the topic-dropped subject can only be interpreted as *við* (‘we’). While unable to license null subjects on its own, the distinct agreement still renders other interpretations illicit.

So, in OI, it is plausible that null subjects in embedded clauses could be identified via two different grammatical devices – both by verb agreement and by antecedents. In example (3:9), for instance, the antecedents (*titull bók* (‘title of the book’) and *orð* (‘word’)) both appear in matrix clauses, directly preceding the corresponding, embedded null subjects. It is possible that main clause antecedents were able to control and identify null subjects in OI embedded clauses, in cases where the embedded subject and the finite verb had established an Agree-relation in T (cf. Holmberg 2010:89, who argues that “control from a higher clause” may be a licensing factor in some NSLs). The subsequent loss of null subjects, the verb agreement nevertheless remaining intact, clearly indicates that the licensing property for null subjects was not agreement. This should not be taken, however, as an argument against the hypothesis that agreement was (at least) a supporting factor in the identification of null thematic subjects in OI (see Frascarelli 2007, Cole 2009 and Sigurðsson 2011 for relevant discussions).

To sum up, null thematic subjects can be attested in OI. As was the case with OE and OHG, it seems that they did not rely on verb agreement in order to be identified, and 3p null subjects were more common than 1p and 2p null

subjects. The proportion of null subjects varies between 2–5% during the first four centuries (excluding the earliest text, *The First Grammarian*, for reasons discussed above), but a significant amount of the null subjects appear in embedded clauses. In these two aspects, OI differ from OE and OHG. The high proportion of embedded null subjects might be related to the fact that finite verbs in OI embedded clauses often appear in non-final positions, unlike OE and OHG embedded clauses, where the finite verb often is situated in the final position.

The brief study of null subjects in OI that is presented here must of course be supplemented by more comprehensive surveys and detailed analyses, in which, for instance, person reference of the null subjects, and the exact syntactic status of the contexts in which null subjects appear, can be ascertained. This falls well beyond the scope of the present work.

3.4. Null subjects in Old Swedish

In traditional studies of OS, such as Pettersson (1959) and Wessén (1965), the possibility to omit referential subjects is noted and briefly discussed. Wessén (1965:192f) assumes that OS null thematic subjects mainly occur in embedded clauses, but Falk (1993:150), in her study of non-referential null subjects in the history of Swedish, presents a contradictory view:

Some brief investigations I have made in Old Swedish show that referential *pro* is uncommon and that most examples are found in main clauses. However, isolated examples are also found in embedded clauses. (Falk 1993:150)

The matter is further investigated in a thesis by Håkansson (2008), a careful, comprehensive and detailed analysis of null thematic subjects in OS. A substantial part of the remainder of this section is build upon that work.

Some OS examples, which are taken from Håkansson (2008:77f), are presented in (3:10).

- (3:10) a. þar gierþi kirchiu apra
 there built church other
 ‘There **he** built another church.’

- b. Mangur kunungar stridu agutland miþan hapit war.
many kings fought against-Gotland while pagan was
 ‘Many kings fought against Gotland when **it** was pagan.’

There are very few null thematic subjects even in the oldest texts (from the 13th century). Håkansson (2008:113) finds that 96% of all subjects are overt in OS (in this number, impersonal subjects are included), leaving only 4% null subjects. He is nevertheless able to conclude that, as in OE, OHG, and OI, 3p null subjects are by far the most frequent:

Omitted subjects that refer to third person dominate in all periods [...]. (Håkansson 2008:106; HR translation)

Furthermore, singular null subjects were more common than plural in OS, although there was only one verb form for singular in OS; in some cases, however, 1sg was marked by *-r* (see table 3:8).

Table 3:8. OS verb agreement (weak verbs, present and past tense indicative).

num.	pers.	present	past
sing.	1	-a(r)	-aþi
	2	-a	
	3		
plural	1	-um	-aþum
	2	-in	-þin
	3	-a	-aþu
infinitive		-a	

As shown by table 3:8, there are notable syncretisms in the OS declension paradigm. There are no distinct singular forms in neither the present, nor the past tense (the 1sg suffix *-r* is a rare exception), and in the present tense 3pl is furthermore identical to the infinitival form. Still, 3p null subjects dominate throughout the OS period, as shown by table 3:9, which is taken from Håkansson (2008:115).

Table 3:9. Null subjects in OS (after Håkansson 2008:115).

pers.	total	overt subj.	null subj.
1	167	98% (164)	2% (3)
2	132	100% (132)	0% (0)
3	809	95% (765)	5 % (44)
Σ	1108	96% (1 061)	4% (47)

It is apparent that 1p and 2p subjects almost always are overt in OS – no 2p null subjects were found in Håkansson's sample of OS texts – while 3p subjects can be omitted, albeit infrequently, although the verb forms for both 3sg and 3pl are non-distinct. The OS data accordingly suggest (again) that the hypothesis that there is an equivalence relation between “rich” agreement and thematic null subjects is untenable, at least when it comes to the OG languages.

OS also displays the same pattern as OHG concerning the syntactic distribution of null thematic subejcts. Håkansson (2008:101ff) concludes that null subjects are most frequently found in main clauses; only 18% of the OS null subjects appear in embedded clauses.

Building on ideas presented by Faarlund (2003), Håkansson explains the loss of referential null subjects as a case of syntactic grammaticalization. He argues that in OS, there was no EPP-driven movement to SpecTP, but this position was an A'-position, accomodating different syntactic constituents. In example (3:11; taken from Håkansson 2008:151), a temporal adverbial seems to occupy SpecTP, while the subject *iak* ('I') appears in a lower position.⁹

(3:11) *sum nu havir iak taltt*
that now have I counted
 'that I have counted now.'

⁹ Stylistic Fronting is common in OS, and may be of relevance here too, but there are a great number of analytical approaches to Stylistic Inversion, and therefore it is not discussed further – for a recent investigation of Stylistic Fronting in Icelandic and some related languages, see Angantýsson (2011:145ff).

Example (3:11) furthermore demonstrates that OS subject were not required to move to SpecTP. This is further underlined by the possibility to place the subject in a clause-final position in OS main clauses (see example (3:12); the example is taken from Håkansson 2008:176).

(3:12) nu uarþær dræpin bonda bryti
now is killed farmer's serf
'now the farmer's serf is killed.'

A final point is of course that subjects, referential as well as expletive, were not obligatorily overt in OS. Håkansson (2008:163) concludes that movement to both SpecCP and SpecTP were triggered by factors relating to text cohesion in OS.

Following an analysis proposed by Faarlund (1993), I argue that the omission of subjects in both verb-second main clauses and subordinate clauses is an effect of movement strategies. Whereas the movement to Spec, IP is determined by syntactic function in Modern Swedish, the corresponding movement is dependent on pragmatic factors in Early Old Swedish. (Håkansson 2008:241)

Håkansson then proceeds to explaining why null subjects became ungrammatical in OS, focusing on the loss of OV-word order in OI (as mentioned above) and in OS.

According to the *Predicate Internal Subject Hypothesis* (cf. e.g. Hornstein et al 2005:80f), both subjects and objects are merged in VP. Given that two arguments cannot remain in the VP at Spell-Out (cf. Alexiadou & Anagnostopoulou 2001), Håkansson (2008:206ff) argues that in a pure OV-language, the direct object cannot remain in the VP in Spell-Out but must evacuate the VP and find a landing site in the structure above VP.¹⁰ Since both SpecTP and SpecCP were available in OS, the object often ends up there, pragmatical factors determining which landing site is best suited. As for the subject, it can either remain in VP, or move to a higher position, and the incentive for this move would also be pragmatic. This is the reason why subjects appear in various structural positions in OS. Håkansson (2008:215)

¹⁰ This argumentation is based on the view that XP:s are always head-initial – for an recent account of loss the of OV in OE that in stead assumes a shift from head-final to head-initial VP, see Taylor & Pintzuk (2012).

demonstrates that there is a clear temporal correlation between OV-word order (only clauses with DP-objects are included in his study) and null subjects in OS. Both of these phenomena decrease during the earliest stages of OS, and both reach almost zero in the period 1375–1450; in texts from this period, only 2% of the clauses are OV, and in only 1% of all clauses do we find null subjects.

In this section, I have demonstrated that also in the history of Swedish, there is a chronological correlation between the loss of OV-word order and the emergence of a requirement to pronounce subjects. More specifically, the usage of clauses without overt subjects seem to become restricted at the same time as Swedish loses a pure OV-grammar. (Håkansson 2008:217; HR translation)

In turn, the loss of OV-word order is supposed to be caused by morphological changes in OS, especially the successive appearance of obligatory articles, a novelty that indicates that the DP-structure evolved into greater complexity. Thereby also new feature-checking possibilities and requirements emerged (cf. Delsing 1999). As a consequence, more DP-objects were required to have a filled D, and DP-objects with a filled D-position could be featurally satisfied within the VP. This syntactic option made the evidence for a pure OV-grammar gradually less visible, eventually resulting in a VO-grammar with a specific, syntactically determined, slot for the subject: SpecTP. In such a grammar, null thematic subjects are not possible, Håkansson (2008) argues, although null expletives may be allowed during the unstable period when the new grammar is settling.

Håkansson's explanation for the loss of null subjects in OS is appealing, since it traces a syntactic change back to an evidently independent change, and since it is supported by data from Icelandic. As shown by Schlachter (2012:138ff), also in OHG verb-final main clauses were relatively frequent, but they seem to have remained as a syntactic option also after the null subjects disappeared, although there is a marked decline in the end of the OHG period. Old English too lost declarative main clauses with OV-word order (cf. Kemenade 1987, Pintzuk 1996, Trips 2002, Taylor & van der Wurff 2005, Taylor & Pintzuk 2012 etc.) at about the same time as the null subjects disappeared – which, according to Kemenade (1987), they did before the 13th century. However, while the new word order in OS may have been driven by changes in the system of determiners, as proposed by Håkansson (2008), the

similar changes in OE, OHG and Icelandic have been attributed to various other factors, such as for instance weakening of the case morphology (Hróarsdóttir 1996 for Icelandic, Roberts 1997 for OE), the emergence of V2-word order (Schlachter 2012 for OHG), prosody (Taylor 2005 for OE) or Scandinavian influence (Trips 2002 for OE).¹¹ As a matter of fact, the shift from OV to VO in OE has attracted substantial interest from historical linguists, as underlined by e.g. Taylor & van der Wurff (2005:1).

Whether judged by the amount of intrinsic interest, the number of knock-on effects, or the sheer volume of scholarly work devoted to it, it seems safe to say that one of the major issues in English historical syntax is the shift from object–verb (OV) to verb–object (VO) order. (Taylor & van der Wurff 2005:1)

In the present work, it is not possible to do justice to the vast literature concerning this salient word order shift in OE, nor in any other of the OG languages. Nevertheless, it has been shown in this section that there appears to be a temporal coincidence between loss of OV-word order and null thematic subjects in all of the OG-languages that are included in this study. This fact suggests strongly that there is a general, underlying pattern of change that is not caused by any language-specific developments. This issue is discussed further in section 3.6.

3.5. Common properties of null subjects in Old Germanic

The survey of null subjects in OG has shown that there are striking similarities when it comes to the syntactic properties of thematic null subjects in OE, OHG, OI, and OS.

First, it seems clear that there is no apparent association between verb agreement and null subjects in any of the languages. On the contrary, in OE and OS 3p thematic null subjects are most frequent, although the respective verb forms in these cases are clearly non-distinct (see tables 3:2 and 3:8). And while the agreement in OHG and OI display six different forms (as illustrated in tables 3:5 and 3:6), distinguishing number as well as person, it has been shown, and pointed out, by Sigurðsson (1993, 2011), Axel (2007) and Schlachter (2012)

¹¹ *English Language and Linguistics* (2005:1) is a special issue on OV and VO in the history of English, including, *inter alia*, a critical review of Trips (2002).

that the successive loss of thematic null subjects in the respective languages did not correspond to any simultaneous weakening of the inflection system. We also find that in OE, OHG and OS, thematic null subjects appeared in verb-final clauses, suggesting that the finite verb did not need to move to T in order to establish an Agree-relation with the null subject. In sum, there are three solid arguments against the hypothesis that null thematic subjects in OG were dependent on “rich” agreement: null subjects appeared in spite of non-distinct agreement, no adjacency between the subject and the finite verb was necessary, and the diachronic developments in the respective languages suggest that verb agreement and thematic null subjects were separate phenomena.

Two further similarities are that the thematic null subjects in all of these languages in general required linguistically expressed antecedents, unlike acknowledged NSLs, and that the null subjects were quite rare in embedded clauses, with the exception for OI. Above I claimed that OI embedded clauses differed from embedded clauses in OE, OHG and OS in that the finite verb often raised to T, which arguably facilitated the omission of an overt subject. Furthermore, examples such as (3:9) indicate that OI embedded null subjects often were controlled by close-range antecedents in the matrix clause.

Yet another common feature of the OG languages is that 3p null subjects were markedly more frequent than other types of null subjects (as shown in tables 3:3, 3:4 and 3:9), and, finally, an obvious correlation between the OG languages is of course that the thematic null subjects became ungrammatical in the early stages of the different languages, Icelandic again being the exception. Taken together with the other similarities, it seems reasonable to assume a pan-Germanic perspective in the search for possible explanations for the syntactic characteristics of null thematic subjects in OG, and for the eventual loss. In the following section, I set out to propose an outline for such explanations.

3.6. The loss of null subjects in Old Germanic

3.6.1. Contextual identification of null thematic subjects in OG

As has been discussed above, Faarlund (2003), Håkansson (2008) and Schlachter (2012) assume that the loss of thematic null subjects in OI, OS and

OHG, respectively, is to be seen as a consequence of a syntactic change in the prefield of the clause. The basic idea is that the canonical subject position, SpecTP, was not dedicated for the subject in OG. Rather, both SpecCP and SpecTP were A'-positions, allowing for movement of various constituents into these positions due to factors relating to information structure (cf. Los et al 2012 for an overview of the recent research in this field). Accordingly, there were no syntactic EPP-features in T, forcing the subject and the finite verb to establish an overt Agree-location, but both the subject and the finite verb were allowed to remain in the VP in OG.¹² This is the reason why verb-final main clauses, subject-final clauses and OV-word order seem to be perfectly grammatical in the four OG-languages that have been discussed above. As for the thematic null subjects, we have seen that they for instance were unrelated to morphological agreement (expressed by the finite verb), and that they in general required overt antecedents in the preceding context. Therefore, one can conclude that thematic null subjects in Old Germanic were contextually identified, being topic-dropped from one of the two available A'-positions (SpecCP and SpecTP).

The suggestion that OG had no syntactic EPP-features in T and C has some implications that are further discussed below.

3.6.2. Null thematic subjects and narrative inversion

Given the hypothesis that there were no syntactic EPP-features neither in T nor in C in OG, we would furthermore expect to find OG clauses where both SpecTP and SpecCP were devoid of lexical material, although the finite verb was situated in T or C. If no constituent merged in SpecTP or SpecCP for information structural reasons, a declarative main clause would accordingly display V1-word order, i.e. narrative inversion (cf. Alving 1916, Sigurðsson 1990, Axel 2007, Calle-Martín & Miranda Garcia 2010, Petrova 2011 etc.). However, if an EPP-feature was eventually developed, forcing constituents to merge in Spec-positions in the prefield of the clause, we would expect V1-clauses to become successively rarer. The hypothesis that OG lacked syntactic EPP-features in T and C therefore predicts that narrative inversion should be

¹² Another view is presented by Biberauer & Roberts (2005), who suggest that there was an EPP-feature in OE, and that also XPs containing the subject could merge in SpecTP by pied-piping, thereby satisfying the probing EPP-feature in T.

attested in the OG-languages, and, crucially, that this syntactic option should also become increasingly infrequent at about the same time as null thematic subjects, OV-word order, verb-final clauses, and subject-final clauses become less frequent; all of these syntactic constructions should in other words change in concert, more or less.

This prediction is borne out. In a recent study of narrative inversion in OE, Calle-Martín and Miranda Garcia remark “The decreasing number of instances of V1 in late OE may be tentatively connected with the progressive standardization of the marked V2 rule in English [...]” (Calle-Martin & Miranda Garcia 2010:52). Axel (2007:170f) notes that narrative inversion was common in OHG, and that is missing in MHG (cf. also Petrova 2011), while Sigurðsson (1990:46) points out that although narrative inversion was more common in OI, it is still found in contemporary Icelandic, although it appears to be restricted to some written genres:

Declarative V1 is typical of many of the best known Old Icelandic texts. Narrative texts do not take such a central position in the modern literature. Accordingly, declarative V1 is a much more characteristic feature of the preserved Old Icelandic texts than of Modern Icelandic prose in general. (Sigurðsson 1990:46)

Since null subjects still occur in some genres in Icelandic, it is not surprising that also narrative inversion is attested, albeit sporadically.

As for OS, a classic study by Alving (1916) shows that narrative inversion was relatively uncommon. Yet, Alving (1916:8ff) states that a significant decline occurred in the shift between late OS and early modern Swedish (in the first half of the 16th century). For instance, in the translation of the New Testament from 1526 there are about 30 instances of narrative inversion in the gospel of Matthew. In the final translation of the entire Bible (1541), nine of these have been changed so that the subject precedes the finite verb. According to Alving (1916:12), narrative inversion was “a pure exceptional phenomenon” [HR translation] in early modern Swedish.

So, we can conclude that narrative inversion became less frequent in OE, OHG and OS at about the same time as the number of thematic null subjects decreased. The observation that the loss of null thematic subjects in OG correlates in time with the loss of narrative inversion indicates that these two languages changes were related to each other. The explanation for this is that

both phenomena were dependent on the absence of syntactic EPP-features in T and C. Below, the eventual development of such features in OG is discussed further.

3.6.3. EPP and information structure

It seems that the OG languages developed from a stage without syntactic EPP-features in T and C into languages with syntactically determined V2-word order in main clauses, the grammar of which did not license null thematic subjects. In this section, I will present an outline of how this change might have proceeded.

First, it is important to point out that OE differed from OHG, OI and OS in that clauses with some types of topicalized constituents and pronominal subjects regularly displayed V3-word order (cf. Hinterhölzl & Petrova 2010, Los 2012). Example (3:13) is taken from Los (2012:4)

- (3:13) And seo eadiga M. handaupp ahof and hi to gode gebæd
 and the blessed M. handsup lifted and her to God prayed
 ‘and the blessed M. lifted up her hands and prayed to God’

Los (2012) argues that this indicates that the OE finite verb could either appear in C, yielding a V2-clause, or in T, resulting in a V3-clause. The different landing sites coded different information structural aspects:

The different positions for pronominal subjects [...] could perhaps be regarded as the outcome of what were originally two different verb placement rules, one motivated by a need to mark off foci, which would include verb movement after first-position elements like question words, negation, and contrastively focused phrases, and another verb placement rule to mark off topics and other backgrounded information. (Los 2012:4)

The verb placement rules suggested by Los (2012) corresponds to movement to C and T, respectively; she assumes that constituents which were marked +Focus merged in SpecCP, triggering verb movement to C, while +Topic constituents merged in SpecTP, requiring the finite verb to move to T. Accordingly, the position of the finite verb in OE was decided by information structure. The explanation for the verb placement variation in OE presented by Los (2012) is backed up by a recent study of the placement of overt subjects in the Romance languages. Giurgea & Ramberger (2012) proposes that T in these languages has

information structural EPP-features, i.e. constituents are attracted to SpecTP not due to morphosyntax, but to information structure.

We explain the differences between preverbal subjects and other fronted constituents by assuming that the EPP in T is not connected to agreement features, but to a probe related to information structure. (Giurgea & Ramberger 2012:43)

In cases where there is no proper goal for the probe in T, the closest constituent is merged in SpecTP due to a last resort-mechanism, and the closest constituent, in turn, is in general the subject in SpecVP, according to Giurgea & Ramberger (2012).

At this stage, recall that null thematic subjects in the OG-languages did not require verb movement to T or C (as has been demonstrated in this chapter). I take this to indicate that there were no EPP-features of any kind associated with these heads in early OG, not even EPP-features relating to information structure. Let us accordingly assume that the early OG-languages originally had no EPP-features at all, neither in T nor in C, while the modern Germanic languages clearly have syntactic EPP-features in both of these heads. An intermediate stage would be a language with EPP-features relating to information structure, in line with not only Los (2012) and Giurgea & Ramberger (2012), but also with the historical linguists Faarlund (2003), Håkansson (2008), and Schlachter (2012). They all present similar proposals, although in slightly different terms.

The tentative development is illustrated in (3:14); *EPP-IS* in (3:14) indicates that the relevant head carries EPP-features relating to information structure, while *EPP-synt.* shows that T or C have syntactically determined EPP-features. The head C is in stage 3 assumed to host both types of EPP-features (see below).

(3:14) stage 1:	[SpecCP C- EPP [SpecTP T- EPP [VP]]]
stage 2:	[SpecCP C- <i>EPP-IS</i> [SpecTP T- <i>EPP-IS</i> [VP]]]
stage 3:	[SpecCP C- <i>EPP-IS/synt.</i> [SpecTP T- <i>EPP-synt.</i> [VP]]]

In stage 1, there are no EPP-features, allowing for any constituent to move to SpecTP or SpecCP (perhaps due to a combination of prosodic and information-

structural reasons); these positions did not need to be filled, however. Stages 1 and 2 both allow contextually identified null thematic subjects, since it is possible to topic-drop subjects from SpecTP or SpecCP in both of these stages. A crucial difference is that topic-dropped subjects in stage 2 require verb movement to T or C, since the EPP-IS-features of the subject must be deleted prior to Spell-Out.¹³ In the final stage, stage 3, subjects must move to SpecTP and must be overt, unless they can merge in SpecCP and be topic-dropped there, being context-linked to an antecedent in the discourse (cf. Cole 2010, Sigurðsson 2011). In this stage, the finite verb moves to T for syntactic EPP-reasons and then to C.

It is not clear to me why the finite verb must move to C in the Germanic languages (with the exception for English), although this question has been a prominent issue in studies of Germanic syntax – Sigurðsson (1990:62) underlines that “a really convincing explanation of I-to-C has not yet been developed”, and this is still true, I think (see discussions in e.g. Hinterhölzl & Petrova 2010, Petrova 2011 etc.). The V2-requirement indicates that the move is conditioned by syntax, while the fact that the virtually any type of constituent can merge in SpecCP, and that this constituent is interpreted as some kind of topic, in general, leads us to believe that movement to this slot is triggered by information structure. This uncertainty is illustrated by the double nature of modern Germanic EPP-features in C in (3:14).

A crucial question is of course why the OG languages changed, first from stage 1 to stage 2, and then from stage 2 to stage 3. The explanations presented by Faarlund (2003), Håkansson (2008), Schlachter (2012) and Los (2012) principally concern the latter change (stage 2 to stage 3), not the initial emergence of EPP-IS-features in T and C. Clearly, since V1-sentences was not the norm in any of the early OG-languages, constituents nevertheless must have merged in SpecTP and/or SpecCP for other reasons, before the EPP-IS-features were developed.

A possible explanation is that prosodic factors had a decisive influence on word order in early OG. On this note, Taylor (2005:140) states “[...] because prosodic structure is related to syntactic structure in a rule-based way, it is

¹³ Another difference is of course that also objects could be topic-dropped in stage 1, given that they were properly contextually identified (cf. Sigurðsson 2011:278ff).

possible to recover some aspects of syntactic structure from prosodic structure.” Indeed, a rather large portion of OG texts had specific metrical properties (such as OE *Beowulf*, OHG *Hildebrandslied*, the OS chronicles, Icelandic skaldic poetry, the Edda literature etc.). Furthermore, the old Scandinavian laws were memorized and recited aloud by a *lagsagoman* (Icelandic *lögsögumaður*), and were obviously designed accordingly, with alliterations and other mnemonic devices, which were preserved when the laws eventually were written down. Bearing in mind, too, that OG texts in general were read (or sung) aloud, it is not inconceivable that prosody has had an impact on sentence structure in the extant OG texts. Prosodically motivated word order variation is not unknown in the languages of the world. For instance, Harfurd & Demuth (1999) argue that certain cases of variation between VS- and SV-word order in Bantu languages are decided by prosody: “Under our analysis, the motivation for movement in Bantu is purely prosodic” (Harfurd & Demuth 1999:22).

Tentatively assuming that this is on the right track, it follows that variation between stressed and unstressed syllables, the number of syllables in various constituents, as well as the cohesion of metrical units, should have affected OG word order. At some stage, however, pre-verbal constituents may have been interpreted as principally significant from an information-structural perspective, according to a general cognitive or stylistic strategy of 'what comes first is most important' (cf. Leech & Short 1981:236). Such an interpretation would infer an eventual syntactic reanalysis, i.e., the establishment of EPP-IS-features in T (and C).

As for the following step, the change from EPP-IS-features to syntactic EPP-features, Faarlund (2003:132) claims that frequency may have played a role (cf. the second quote in section 3.3 above), the idea being that since subjects often are topics, a subject/topic in SpecTP could be assumed to have merged for syntactic rather than information-structural reasons. As soon as a syntactic EPP-feature has been developed, SpecTP can no longer host any other constituents than the syntactic subject in SpecTP— objects and other parts of the clause must therefore either remain in VP or merge in SpecCP (in main clauses). The loss of OV-word order is in this perspective to be seen as a consequence of the syntactic change, rather than the trigger of it (cf. Håkansson 2008, and the discussion about OS in section 3.5). Likewise, subject-final clauses, verb-final

clauses and narrative inversion are cumbersome to derive in a V2-language where the finite verb obligatory must merge in T and the subject in SpecTP. As has been shown above, the loss of these constructions in OG coincide in time with the loss of OV-word order and, crucially, the novel requirement that subjects must be overt.

3.6.4. The bias for 3rd person null thematic subjects in Old Germanic

In all of the OG languages, 3p null subjects are more frequent than other types of null subjects. This has of course been noted by every scholar working with the respective languages (as discussed throughout sections 3.2–3.5 in the present chapter). Given the hypothesis pursued here, that null subjects in OG are contextually identified, explanations for the person bias in OG that are based on syntactic identification (i.e., via agreement on the finite verb), such as van Gelderen (2011), cannot be on the mark, and Distinct Agreement (as defined in section 2.4) is likewise irrelevant (although DA may constrain the identification of the null thematic subject).

An explanation for the person bias in OG accordingly must proceed from the observation that contextual identification is the key factor. The question is, then, what properties relating to contextual interpretation may make 3p null subjects easier to derive than 1p and 2p null subjects in OG? Given the proposals presented by for instance Sigurðsson (2011:283; see the discussion in section 2.3.), 1p and 2p null subjects are inherently C/edge-linked, and should for this reason be *easier* to process than 3p null subjects, not harder.¹⁴ But recall that also context scanning is a part of context linking, according to Sigurðsson:

While arguments are ϕ -computed under CLn matching in narrow syntax, their definite reference is decided by clause-external *context scanning*, either under distant Agree/control [...] or by extrasyntactic means. Together, CLn matching and context scanning yield *context linking* [...] (Sigurðsson 2011:283)

Ascertaining the reference of any argumental subject pronoun hence involves context scanning, a principled search for the correct referential point of the

¹⁴ The assumption that 1p and 2p pronouns have a special grammatical status, being Speech Act Participants (SAPs), goes back to Postal (1966). For more discussions about SAPs and null subjects, see Cole (2010) and Wratil (2011:119ff).

pronoun. For instance, 1sg (*I*) refers to a singular speaker who participates in the ongoing discourse. Being used by speaker A, it refers to speaker A, but when used by speaker B, it refers to speaker B.¹⁵ Interestingly, 1p and 2p pronouns are used interchangeably by the speaker and the hearer in a typical conversation, meaning that the pronoun *you*, for instance, does not have a fixed point of reference in a dialogue. Sigurðsson (2011:283) provides the following example:

- (3:15) a. Hey, John, are *you* invited?
 b. No, Sandra, but *you* are.

The 2sg pronoun *you* first refers to John (in 3:15a) and then to Sandra (in 3:15b). Deictic shifts of this type are prevalent in natural discourse, also in very short exchanges. The reference of pronouns that refer to non-participants, i.e. 3p pronouns, is on the other hand more stable, since the speaker and hearer often tend to talk about the same topic for a period of time. For instance, Frascarelli (2007:703) presents an Italian example where seven 3sg pronouns after each other (of which six are null) all refer to the same person, forming a referential chain. She concludes that overt pronouns in Italian, a typical NSL, are used mainly to disentangle the referential properties of 3p pronouns (Frascarelli 2007:703)

[...] strong subjects are not produced to avoid featural ambiguities: the speaker is talking about two men and the ϕ -features expressed with the pronoun *lui* [i.e., *he*] cannot be helpful to identify either (possible) referent. Strong pronouns, on the other hand, avoid ambiguities at a discourse level, since they are used to obviate coreference with respect to the current Aboutness Topic (and, eventually, to propose a shift). (Frascarelli 2007:703)

As long as the point of reference does not change, a null subject is accordingly possible in Italian.

Consider at this point a brief piece of discourse such as (3:16).

- (3:16) a. John_a: I_a would like to know if you_b think he_c's coming.
 b. Jane_b: Why do you_a think I_b should know if he_c's coming?

¹⁵ How pronouns relate to language-external referents is of course an extremely complicated and much-debated issue that cannot be discussed in any depth here.

The SAPs *I* and *you* refer to both the speaker and the hearer, through deictic shift, while the 3sg pronoun *he* remains stable (otherwise, the short exchange would be incomprehensible). In (3:16), this is shown by the indices *a* (referring to *John*), *b* (referring to *Jane*) and *c* (referring to the person being spoken about). Unlike *I* and *you*, *he* refers to the same person throughout the exchange. One can thus claim that *he* is easier to process, since the context scanning result, the established point of reference, for *he* is invariant throughout the discourse, in contrast with the shifting pronouns *I* and *you*. In other words, John and Jane in (3:16) are in agreement when it concerns the reference of *he*, but, following the principles for usage of personal pronouns, they congenially disagree on the reference of *I* and *you*. Each time these pronouns are used, a new context-scanning process must be initiated and a new point of reference must be fixed.

In some genres, also SAPs continuously keep referring to the same person, however. It has been noted that even in typical non-NSLs, such as English, 1p pronouns may be omitted in diary contexts and on postcards, for instance (Haegeman 1990; see section 2.2); arguably, this is made possible by the fact that deictic shifts do not occur in these genres – addressees are rarely, if ever, allowed to assume the role of speaker in a diary.

Let us accordingly entertain the possibility that the deictic shifts that are typical for 1p and 2p pronouns made 3p null thematic subjects easier to derive, in comparison, in OG. It would then be unsurprising that 3p pronouns were omitted more frequently than 1p and 2p pronouns, perhaps especially in the early stages of the OG languages, when the written language had not yet been codified and standardized, hence, presumably, being modeled on the spoken language to a greater extent. Another factor of relevance is that a substantial part of the extant OG texts are religious and/or historical narratives (such as the OE *Beowulf*, the OI saga literature, descriptions of the lives of saints etc.), genres in which 3p reference chains are relatively common, whereas 1p and 2p reference chains occur rather sparingly. In the OG data that have been presented in tables 3:3, 3:4, and 3:9, the number of 3p subjects (null as well as overt) is very high, compared with 1p and 2p subjects. In OE, 3p subjects make up 59% of all subjects, and the corresponding figure in OHG is 64%, while in OS no less than 73% of all subjects were 3p subjects. This is a clear indication that 3p reference chains must have been considerably more common than 1p and 2p

reference chains in the OG texts that have formed the basis of investigation for the studies discussed above.

While many researchers claim that SAPs are easier to process than non-SAPs (i.e., 3p pronouns) (see Déchaine & Wiltschko 2002 etc.), the OG facts show that 3p pronouns are more prone to be covert in some languages, suggesting that the identification of 3p pronouns in OG was less complex than identification of the SAPs. It has been argued here that this unexpected non-complexity is due to the relation between the pronoun and the point of reference. For a 3p pronoun in a chain of reference, this point is a fixed target, facilitating the omission of the overt subject pronoun, while 1p and 2p subject pronouns constantly keep shifting in this respect.

This suggestion obviously calls for further studies of null subjects in OG, based on hypotheses relating to genre differences (cf. for instance Håkansson 2008:117, who finds that null thematic subjects occur more often in early OS non-religious texts than in religious texts), deictic shifts, referential chains, contextual identification, and/or context scanning, requiring investigations of substantial chunks of text rather than of isolated sentences. Needless to say, such an enterprise cannot be undertaken here, but must be left for future research.